(UPA) government in 2008 last reviewed the matter. It quoted estimates made by the Lal Bahadur Shastri National Academy of Administration (LBSNAA), which reckoned that the potential ceiling surplus land in India was about 21 million hectares. If these estimates are taken as accurate, the land in excess of ceilings acquired and distributed was less than 10 per cent of the potential. Lamenting the lack of progress in the implementation of land ceiling after the 1980s, the Committee on Land Reforms vigorously argued for taking up the ceiling reform agenda again. However, its report did not make any progress.

The Planning Commission captured the policy flipflop in designing and implementing land reforms most poignantly. In its report in 1973, its Task Force noted: 'In no sphere of public activity in our country since Independence has the hiatus between the precept and practice, between policy pronouncements and actual execution, been as great as in the domain of land reforms.'

Conferring 'Ownership' Rights on Tillers and Abolition of Intermediaries, By and Large, Completed in the 1950s and 1960s

Traditionally, land belonged to the king or his latter-day replacement, the republican state. In olden times, peasants had the permission of the state to till the land on the pain of paying tax, usually a part of the produce. As agriculture grew, kings and states started granting ownership/rights to landlords to get the land tilled, collect taxes and pay it to the treasury.

Two systems defining the relationships of the tillers of the land with the states were quite prominent in India at the time of Independence.

First, in large parts of the country, especially under what came to be known as the zamindari system (prevalent in West Bengal, Orissa and a few other states), the intermediary or zamindars enjoyed considerable ownership rights in the land given by the state. Farmers were given permission to till assigned lands and pay the tax to the zamindar, who would in turn pay a